

What else to watch: *Laura* (1944, p.79) ■ *Spellbound* (1945) ■ *Rear Window* (1954) ■ *North by Northwest* (1959) ■ *La jetée* (1962, p.172) ■ *Marnie* (1964) ■ *Bad Education* (2004)

Hitchcock's blondes

Hitchcock favored icy, "sophisticated blondes" in his movies. "We're after the drawing-room type, the real ladies, who become whores once they're in the bedroom," he said.



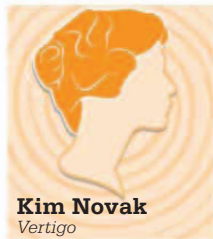
Tippi Hedren
The Birds



Grace Kelly
Rear Window



Ingrid Bergman
Spellbound



Kim Novak
Vertigo



Janet Leigh
Psycho



Eva Marie Saint
North by Northwest



Marlene Dietrich
Stage Fright

for creating cinematic suspense, saying in a 1977 TV interview, "Blondes make the best victims. They're like virgin snow that shows up the bloody footprints."

Vertigo's lead, Scottie, remakes salesgirl Judy Barton (also played by Kim Novak) in Madeleine's image. He removes everything that makes Judy an individual in order to have her conform to this visual archetype, a lifeless host for sexual objectification. Scottie's requirements are hugely specific. He agonizes over the exact shades of gray for Judy's suit, and is disappointed when she returns home with a hairstyle slightly different from the one he chose (changing her from brunette to blonde). Hitchcock may have put together bloodier sequences,

Scottie (James Stewart) is a police officer seen in a rooftop chase at the start of the movie. He slips, and a colleague falls while trying to help him. This is the start of his vertigo.

specifically geared around creating tension, but the subtext of emotional abuse in this sequence, along with the notion that it is a

self-examination by Hitchcock regarding the way he treats women on film, makes it as unsettling as anything he ever filmed.

The fallen star

Another common theme in Hitchcock's movies is the exploration of the concept of the movie star and how it affects the telling of a story, more specifically how stardom could be manipulated to surprise the audience. The most famous example of this is *Psycho*, in which star Janet Leigh is murdered after just 30 minutes, manipulating audience assumptions of the way stories with stars in leading roles usually progress in order to shock them. But while the twist in *Psycho* is loud and unavoidable, in *Vertigo* it is subtle and slow to unfold, and its effect depends on the particular star chosen to play Scottie. »

“He did nothing. The law has little to say on **things left undone.**”

Coroner / Vertigo

